daunting the occasion. I've never felt overawed, and, as strange as it sounds, can almost sight-read the bowler.

Dad opened the batting for Great Totham and partnered Joe Root's father-in-law when he played for a time in Gloucester. He bowled right-handed but batted and played golf left-handed. My grandad tried to teach me to play golf as a right-hander, but as soon as I was alone, I would twirl the club around and play left-handed. Ironically, in everything else I am strongly right-handed.

I would watch left-handed batsmen such as Mark Butcher and Graham Thorpe on TV, then go out into the garden and try to copy them. That's probably where I developed the instinctive trigger movement of going back and across my crease. I never realized I did the double backlift until I was about fifteen. It was an unconscious action; when I tried to take it out of my game for a couple of months I was terrible.

Don Bradman famously hit a golf ball with a stump for hours in his back yard. My classroom, in a cricket sense, was the eleven-yard pitch in the back garden. We taped up tennis balls or used slightly softer practice balls with a seam, known as Incrediballs. Adrian, as the eldest brother, demanded to bowl. Laurence as the youngest, kept wicket. I batted and was highly competitive; Adrian, naturally, tried to knock my head off.

He was quick for his age, and because the pitch was so short, he would never let me play a drive. If I did so, and hit the greenhouse at extra cover, we'd all get in trouble. The ball would come through to me at hip height; that's why and how I learned to play my trademark shots, the cut, the pull and the clip. I was small, and lacked power, but my technique was good.

Occasionally I pretended I was Brian Lara – as a bowler I tried to mimic Darren Gough, Angus Fraser or Gladstone 'no neck' Small – but when Adrian raced in from the patio the challenge was realistic because it was so personal. This was brother against brother, him versus me. I love the individual battle in cricket, within the team context.

It is a game that allows you to share experiences and memories but doesn't always shine the best light on your personality. I've always been stubborn. My grandad once asked me to get my stumps from the garden when it was raining. I refused point blank, even though I was told off for challenging his authority. I argued that since they were mine I could do what I wanted with them.